

Freedom in natural chains: challenges to Aristotle's Notion of freedom for good service in slavery.

Slavery has had a massive historical presence in ancient Greece: in Athens there was a proportion of 4 slaves for every citizen. They were the only reason citizens could dedicate their efforts to political matters and intellectual activities in general without having to worry about physical labor; without slaves Athens could never have been as developed. Aristotle argues against this unjust practice of slavery, but rather identifies natural slaves (Simpson 1997, 1254a13), whom it is just to enslave. This paper will argue that Aristotle's premise of freedom as a reward for good service, within the context of natural slavery, poses challenges to the feasibility of such a trait in the best regime. I will first support this argument by bringing to attention the rule of the body over the soul, then how natural slaves are incapable of good service, and finally how freedom is detrimental to the Aristotelian slave.

First of all, one could ask how a soul can be measured with enough precision that it is judged justly, and which would help to tell apart natural slaves from others. To answer that, Aristotle points at the two types of discursive thinking in a human being: a recognitive one, share by all, which allows us to recognize and understand arguments and its quality, and a deliberative one that natural slaves would lack, that allows one to use their reasoning to come forth with their own ideas (Simpson 1997, 1260a2). On that basis, the natural slave's limited reasoning skills do not allow it to be self-sufficient and it is in his interest to follow and obey a master that by taking care of him

as a possession acts in favor of its self-preservation. On this account, it seems interesting to consider that precisely because natural slaves have their body rule over their souls, they cannot make the choices that would be in their best interest which given their situation would be to find a master under whom work (Simpson 1997, 1260a33). That appears to be considered by Aristotle when he specifies that “the slave by nature is someone who has the power of belonging to another and who shares reason sufficiently to perceive it but not to have it” (Simpson 1997, 1254b20). This entails that the natural slave’s case is quite specific: it only occurs when a human has just enough reason to realize their disadvantageous position but not enough to act independently about it. Furthermore, this excludes a more common case of overwhelming dominance of the body over the soul such that it influences its owner’s perception to think the body’s benefits come before the minds, or similarly its desires over its reason.

Now that we have established the limits of Aristotle’s natural slavery, let us turn to its possibilities: what is the finality of the natural slave?

Secondly, Aristotle’s claim that the best regime offers freedom to slaves as a reward for good service is compatible with definition of natural slavery in Book I. Indeed, the soul rules over the body just like reason rules over desires and like humans rule over tamed animals (Simpson 1997, 1254a28). In all three cases, it is in their preservation interest to be ruled, as if one cannot rule over themselves, the next best alternative is to give someone else rule over yourself (Simpson 1997, 1255b4). However, slavery is not determined by one’s ability to rule over themselves: some are able to do so and are still enslaved. Then, there needs to be a distinction between natural slaves that benefit from being ruled and thus can justly take that position, and unnatural slaves who are forcefully obliged to comply by the use of force. This separation is not made from a difference in physical attributes, or origins, or race: the nature of the soul and its ability to rule over the body

justify one's classification as a natural slave. Following this reasoning, if a slave is capable of good service, which as a subjective concept can only be compared to other services delivered meaning a good service is one that distinguishes itself from others, it indicates this slave shows more spirit and virtue than others as it was able to do something other slaves could not. As previously seen (Simpson 1997,1260a2), an easy way for a slave to distinguish themselves from their peers would be to display initiative and deliberative thinking: feats characteristic of naturally free men. In this sense, natural slaves would never experience the inconvenience of freedom and remain under a master.

Nevertheless, if natural slaves cannot produce good service, what does this unveil about their end as human beings?

Lastly, the premise of freedom as a reward for good service seems to be an unfeasible trait of the best regime. Aristotle distinguishes two types of relationships between master and slave. The first, when their relation is natural as one is virtuous in ruling and the other virtuous in being ruled, is described as beneficial for both and susceptible to creating friendships(Simpson 1997, 1255b4). The second, when their relationship is said to be enforced by law and justified by force, it is said to be a detrimental one (Ibid). This passage indicates how the disposition of someone for their role influences the outcome of their work. This notion seems to be contradictory with the idea of freedom as a reward for good service: the premise would result in the only slaves still working as ones being the ones bad at their tasks, and therefore to some extent undisposed to fulfill it. Moreover, with Aristotle's argument in mind, the more someone is good at being a slave or a master, the more it is in their interest to continue pursuing their end, which would be disrupted by the gift of freedom.

In conclusion, Aristotle's exploration of slavery in ancient Greece reveals the complexities inherent in his philosophical framework. While he criticizes the unjust practice of slavery, his identification of natural slaves introduces a nuanced perspective. The paper contends that Aristotle's premise of offering freedom as a reward for good service within the context of natural slavery poses challenges. Examining the limitations of natural slaves in reasoning and the implications of the body ruling over the soul, it questions the feasibility of freedom as a reward and underscores the intricate dynamics between master and slave, challenging the viability of this Aristotelian notion within the broader context of *The Politics*.

Bibliography :

Aristotle "The Politics" Translated by Peter Simpson, University of North Carolina Press, 1997

Arthur Barrier

Word count : 1080 words